Looking back at the Yatra, my mind goes back to the beginning. There was nostalgia, excitement and expectation; and for many of my fellow citizens, the New Year began pleasantly. The young man's odyssey struck us all the most. As we were discussing it in our drawing rooms, I got a call out of the blue saying, 'Mr Gandhi would like you to join the padyatra in Delhi.' As the song goes, 'Says I to myself, says I … why would I not.' Today it all seems like a reverie, but I did not mind walking as a rule of thumb. I often did so myself when I wanted to switch off and escape the madding crowd.

The next day I got another call: 'Will you join the padyatra at 10 a.m. at Kashmiri Gate on the 4 January?' Being hesitant to brave the harsh Delhi cold, I knew that would always be too early for me! So I asked the caller, 'Could we make it midday?' 'Of course,' came the reply, 'we will pick you up at noon and, instead of Kashmiri Gate, you could join the Yatra in north-east Delhi.' Fantastic, I thought.

My son Arjun was visibly more excited to join the Yatra as we drove to north-east Delhi courtesy of our driver and escort. But catching up with the gargantuan Yatra meant negotiating one hell of a maze on a cold, foggy winter morning. Ultimately we caught up with Rahul Gandhi during a tea break close to midday in a higher secondary school. The timing was perfect, as we entered the school almost simultaneously. Once in the staff room (which they had converted into a temporary tea room), Arjun and I were ushered to a small roundtable. The only person among the ten or so in the room that I recognized was Digvijaya Singh. Even as he began to introduce us to Rahul Gandhi, the latter said he knew me. But when Arjun introduced himself as Aditya's cousin, Rahul Gandhi was surprised. 'You mean Aditya Singh of Kolkata?' Exactly, Aditya had been a classmate of Rahul's at the Doon School.

As the Yatra resumed, Rahul Gandhi said to me, 'Are you serious about walking? You will get pushed around.' I insisted on walking, because had we not walked, the whole exercise would have been a farce. And pushed around we were. I almost lost my spectacles in the melee, but courtesy of Rahul Gandhi we did manage to walk a little, until Raja sahib signalled to